Exceptional Human Experiences Among Pilgrims on the Camino de Santiago: A Typology of Experiences and Transformative Aftereffects

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We have no known conflict of interest to disclose.
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Recommended Citation
Brumec, S., Lavrič, M., & Naterer, A. (2022). Exceptional human experiences among pilgrims on the Camino de Santiago: A typology of experiences and transformative aftereffects. *Psychology of Religion and Spirituality.* Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1037/rel0000456

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Abstract

The increasing popularity of pilgrimage at the Camino de Santiago is one of the most interesting developments in terms of religion and spirituality in the Western world. Based on qualitative and quantitative content analysis of 32 pilgrim travelogues, this study constructs an empirically grounded typology of Exceptional Human Experiences (EHEs) among pilgrims, whereby EHEs are understood as specific combinations of out-of-the-ordinary experiences during the pilgrimage and their transformative aftereffects (TAs). Combining different techniques of coding and statistical analyses, we identify nine basic types of EHEs. The most common type is denoted as *the experience of interconnectedness with the main effect of a higher emphasis on unity and love*. Together with eight other identified types, it forms a coherent worldview that closely resembles the “Being-values" defined by Abraham Maslow. These values are at the core of the process of self-actualization of an individual and typically include notions of interconnectedness, unity, wholeness, simplicity, essentiality, just-rightness, spontaneity, effortlessness, benevolence, honesty, autonomy, and individuality. We conclude that the main effect of walking the Camino is a boost in self-actualization as understood in terms of humanistic psychology. It is also argued that the EHE perspective is a useful approach for studying the experiences of pilgrims at Camino de Santiago, and for other aspects of late modern spirituality as well.

Keywords: Camino de Santiago, Exceptional Human Experiences, Typology, Spirituality, Content analysis

One of the recent surprises in terms of the vitality of religion and spirituality in contemporary Europe came from the renewed interest of (not only) Europeans in pilgrimage. Douglas Challenger writes, “No one could have predicted fifty years ago that we would be experiencing the second great period of world pilgrimage (the first being the late middle ages in the West) in the late 20th and early 21st century, certainly not sociologists of religion” (2014, ch.6, para. 4). Given the increase in numbers attending pilgrimage in recent decades, together with the theoretical implications of this trend, it is not surprising that as Durán-Sánchez et al. (2018) recently showed, publications on religious tourism and pilgrimage are currently experiencing exponential growth.

This study focuses on the Camino de Santiago (in English the Way of St. James) as arguably the most popular pilgrimage in contemporary Western world. The Camino consists of a network of pilgrim's ways leading to the cathedral of Santiago de Compostela, the legendary site of the remains of Saint James. Since1987, when Camino was proclaimed the first European Cultural Itinerary by the Council of Europe and was named one of UNESCO's World Heritage Sites, the yearly number of pilgrims rose from fewer than 3,000 to over 327,000 in 2018 (Pilgrim’s reception office, 2020). The name “El Camino de Santiago” usually refers to the version of the pilgrimage route to Santiago de Compostela, which is almost 800 km long and takes about four to five weeks of walking. It runs from Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port on the French side of the Pyrenees and is the most popular of the routes. Many studies (Farias et. al, 2019, Margry, 2008 , Oviedo et. al, 2014) have shown that modern pilgrimage often transcends traditional religious motives. There is a clear need, as Coleman and Eade (2004) argued, that pilgrimage studies should be extended beyond analyses of pilgrimage as a form of religious journey. For Coleman and Eade, a promising approach would be through focusing on movement as the central element of pilgrimage. This entails, among other things, more focus on pilgrims' experiences and on the transformative

effects of the pilgrimage. In this regard, Tomasi (2002) observed that, since the medieval period, pilgrimage has in general been less focused on religious discourse, which has been increasingly replaced by an emphasis on the experiences of the journey and on related transformations in the self. It is therefore not surprising that pilgrims' experiences at the Camino, as well as the effects of walking the Camino, have been the subject of several scientific studies.

Schnell and Pali (2013) studied the effects of this pilgrimage on a sample of 85 pilgrims. They found that pilgrims, immediately after peregrination as well as four months later, reported experiencing life as significantly more meaningful. Most pilgrims also reported strengthening their commitment to self-transcendence and self-actualization.

Lopez (2013) focused on reported transformative effects of the Camino pilgrimage by examining 63 travel diaries which Italian pilgrims published on the internet. She found that pilgrims tend to describe their pilgrimage as a cathartic experience, that is, an experience that transformed their lives and priorities.

Lavrič and Brumec (2020) conducted a short online survey of pilgrims (n = 102) about self-reported transformative aftereffects of the Camino. They found that a strong increase of self-actualization as measured by the Kaufman (2018) Characteristics of Self-actualization Scale (CSAS) was the central psychological aftereffect of walking the Camino. In addition, they observed notable changes in values as measured by the Short Schwartz's values questionnaire (Lindeman & Verkasalo, 2005). The pilgrims reported substantial increases in the values of universalism and benevolence and a decrease in the importance of the values that emphasize the pursuit of self-interest, success and dominance over others (power and achievement).

Lobato and Sainz (2020) conducted a study of the identity fusion, "a visceral union between personal and group identity" (p. 502) among the pilgrims (n = 609) at the finishing

point of the Camino and three months later. They concluded that engaging in ritual practices and recalling episodic memories of the pilgrimage through contact with other pilgrims contribute to maintaining identity fusion. They also argue that once participants are fused with the pilgrim identity, they tend to remain fused even when the pilgrimage is over, even if they do not engage regularly in these practices.

Recently Feliu-Soler et al. (2021) explored the effects of the pilgrimage on mindfulness on a large sample of participants undertaking the Camino de Santiago pilgrimage (baseline: n = 800; pre-post analyses: n = 314). Their results showed increased mindfulness skills after the pilgrimage experience, suggesting that pilgrimage experience could be a way to foster mindfulness cognitive skills.

In this article, we analyze reports of the experiences of pilgrims of the Camino within the paradigm of Exceptional Human Experiences (EHEs). The term was coined by Rhea White (1993), who tried to capture spontaneously emerging unusual experiences, which researchers and practitioners deal with in different disciplines separately, and conceptualized them as, for example, religious (James, 1902/2008), mystical (Stace, 1961), anomalous (Cardeña et al., 2017), peak experiences (Maslow, 1964/1994) and awakening experiences (Taylor & Egeto-Szabo, 2017). White made a distinction between exceptional experiences (EEs) and EHEs. An exceptional experience is understood as an anomalous event for which there are few, if any, acceptable rational explanations within current Western culture. These are out-of-the-ordinary experiences that do not conform to the mainstream worldview paradigm. According to White, these kinds of experiences tend to be neglected by researchers because of their mystical and anomalous nature. However, if EEs have a real effect on long-term human behavior, they become much more relevant for scientific consideration. EHEs are defined as a combination of EEs and their TAs. Simply put, they are extraordinary experiences that transform the individual who has them. According to White, the adjective

"human" is there to suggest these experiences contribute to greater expression of the human potential of an individual.

This idea has found substantial empirical support. Existing research suggests that the aftereffects included in EHEs involve changes like (1) an increased sense of life meaning and purpose, (2) changes in values and attitudes, especially in terms of less materialistic and more altruistic values and in terms of higher social trust, (3) increased feelings of self-actualization, (4) increased interest in spirituality, (5) increased level of spiritual beliefs (like belief in life after death or belief in a higher force or being) and (6) increased sense of well-being (Braud, 2012; Cardeña et al., 2017; Greyson & Ring, 2004; Kennedy et. al., 1994; Kennedy & Kanthamani, 1995; Klemenc-Ketiš, 2010; Palmer & Braud, 2002; Taylor & Egeto-Szabo, 2017; Waldron, 1998). Most of these aftereffects can be seen in accounts of the psychological and spiritual effects of the Camino de Santiago pilgrimage experience (Feliu-Soler et al., 2021, Lavrič & Brumec, 2020, Lobato & Sainz, 2020, Lopez, 2013, Schnell & Pali, 2013).

We had four main reasons for choosing the EHE perspective. First, mindful of the fact that the contemporary literature does offer convincing typologies of religious experiences (Hardy, 1979), we followed the literature suggesting that the religious dimension is not central to the motives or experiences of most pilgrims at the Camino (Farias et al., 2019, Oviedo et al., 2014, Schnell & Pali, 2013). We opted for a perspective that entails a wider range of pilgrims' experiences and their aftereffects.

The second reason for choosing the EHE perspective lies in the fact there are many typical triggers of EHEs present among pilgrims on the Camino. White (1994) identified exposure to scenes of natural beauty, visiting sacred places such as shrines and cathedrals, and intense involvement in meaningful long-term repetitive activities, such as running or walking (p. 194). All these elements are present among pilgrims on the Camino.

The third reason is that we aimed to measure not only the experiences on the pilgrimage but also their TAs. The perspective of EHEs provides a framework for creating meaningful connections between experiences and aftereffects.

Fourth, there are many published pilgrim travelogues describing both their experiences on the Camino and the aftereffects of the pilgrimage. Thus, we see pilgrims' autobiographical accounts as an excellent source of data for scientific analysis. Indeed, several existing studies of pilgrims' experiences are based on travelers' accounts (Beek, 2018; Courtney, 2014; Frey, 1998; Lopez, 2013).

This study is based on a content analysis of autobiographical accounts of walking the Camino and aims at creating a typology of EEs and a typology of TAs on this basis. A good point of departure for such an analysis is White's typology of EHEs. She initially (1993) identified approximately 100 kinds of EHEs, which she organized into five major classes: mystical and unitive experiences, psychical experiences, encounter experiences, unusual death-related experiences, and exceptional normal (later called enhanced) experiences. White and Brown later expanded the list to include approximately 200 types of EHEs (2000) and organized these into nine classes (Braud, 2012) including mystical and unitive experiences, psychical experiences, encounter experiences, unusual death-related experiences, peak experiences, exceptional human performances (feats), healing experiences, desolation/nadir experiences, and dissociation experiences.

Our goal was to create an inductively derived typology of EEs and TAs among pilgrims on the Camino and then to examine the correlations between individual types from the two basic categories. We set out to find answers to three basic research questions:

1. How can the EEs reported by pilgrims on the Camino de Santiago be empirically categorized into a typology?

2. How can the reported TAs by pilgrims on the Camino de Santiago be empirically categorized into a typology?

3. What are the strongest correlations between types of EEs and TAs? Within this question, we aimed to find the most typical combinations of EEs and TAs and by doing so to identify the most typical EHEs among pilgrims on the Camino de Santiago.

These questions were pursued on the basic assumptions of subtle ontological realism (Hammersley, 1992) and epistemological constructivism (Raskin, 2002). Accordingly, our study is based on the assumption that (1) there is a real world that exists independently of our perceptions and theories and that (2) our (including scientific) understanding of the world is inevitably a construction from our own perspectives and standpoint. Based on the second point, we opted for an interpretivist approach, according to which social reality is best approached through interpreting actors' understanding of events.

Method

This research was initially divided into two stages, of which the first took shape primarily as a qualitative and quantitative content analysis of 32 travelogue testimonies about the Camino de Santiago pilgrimage,[1] written by pilgrims themselves, published in book form in the Slovene language, and recorded in the Slovenian library information system COBISS (Co-operative Online Bibliographic System & Services). Most books (23) are the work of Slovenian authors, while six were written by authors from other countries and translated into Slovene. It is important to note that one book by a Slovenian author was in fact written by the first author of this article, who had first-hand experience as a pilgrim on Camino. This had a profound impact on our analysis, for it added to both the validity of our interpretations and much appreciated sincerity, which is a crucial component within qualitative research (Tracey,

[1] In Appendix is List of analyzed travelogues.

2010: 7). Seven foreign authors include two Frenchmen (Potdevin, 2013; Rufin, 2015), three Americans (Gray & Skeesuck, 2017; MacLaine, 2000), one Croatian (Kapetanović, 2017), and one Irishman (McManus, 2014).

We developed an inductively derived Typology of EEs and TAs as part of the research aimed to provide a data-based theoretical explanation of the Camino de Santiago pilgrimage experience in late modernity. Analysis was performed using computer data processing, with QDA Miner software, where we imported and encoded the books in rtf files. Text coding was the central part of data processing. In the first step, we applied single-stage open coding to establish inductive, content-driven concepts by analyzing the incidents or activities as potential indicators of the pilgrimage experience. We identified 346 codes grounded in the data. In the second step, we group the concepts into categories that pertained to the same phenomenon into higher level and more abstract codes. The final coding framework included 29 categories. We arranged different kinds of reported unusual experiences (such as interconnectedness) in the category of *Exceptional experiences*, and different effects (such as strengthening of intuition) in *Transformational aftereffects.* These two categories correspond to EHEs theoretical framework. In the next step, we further explored the relationship between codes by computation of similarity indices and co-occurrence indices, enabling us to perform cluster analysis and multidimensional scaling on selected codes. We display our results in the form of concept maps.

Since our sample was defined in size and content in advance, data saturation, or the point when the “coding of new data yields fewer and eventually no new examples” of categories (Payne 2021: 212), was not of crucial importance. Nevertheless, after processing all 32 cases, we found that our basic results stabilized after analyzing the first 23 cases as we did not identify any new concept related to EHE's theoretical framework. We suggest that this is an indication that the entire sample of 32 cases yielded reliable results in terms of final

concepts included in both final typologies. Based on this suggestion, we are also able to assess the quality of data collected, about their richness, depth, diversity, and complexity.

In the second stage, following the qualitative and quantitative content analysis, we used quantitative results of the content analysis. To find the most typical combinations of types of EEs on the Camino and types of TAs, we exported the frequencies of relevant data to SPSS, where we conducted correlational analyses.

Results

Typology of EEs

To produce a typology of EEs, we calculated co-occurrence and similarity indexes for 56 codes relating to EEs. In the books analyzed, they occur 4761 times, on average 148 times per author.

As Figure 1 shows, the code co-occurrance yielded a nine-cluster solution. Individual clusters were considered as specific types of EEs. These types are more thoroughly presented in the implementation matrix (Table 1).

The most common type of EEs in the texts analyzed can be called the EXPERIENCE OF INTERCONNECTEDNESS, with a frequency of 1307 or 28% of all codes related to EEs. An average code occurrence is 41 codes per analyzed author. Based on the codes that make up the first cluster, we can describe it as the strong perception of an individual that he or she is deeply integrated into a larger whole, usually described as the entire universe. This feeling tends to be accompanied by the perception of an universal unifying force or energy, which triggers feelings of joy and happiness. This type of EE neatly fits White's first class of EHEs - mystical and unitive experience.

The second most common type of EE, with an average code occurrence of 26, can be described as an EXPERIENCE OF DEEP CALM AND RECONCILIATION. It is based on an experience of inner peace that usually manifests itself after a process of self-exploration

and self-confrontation when walking in nature and silence. It refers to codes pointing to descriptions of things such as the experience of reconciliation, being all by oneself, feeling and appreciating peace and silence, admiring the beauty of nature, and Meseta, an uninhabited plateau 800 m above sea level which is part of the geography of the Camino.The description of an experience of deep calm and reconciliation fits well with White's type called peace beyond understanding (White, 2000).

With an average of 19 code occurrences per author, RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE is the third most common type of EE in our analysis. It can be defined as an experience of direct connection to God or some other transcendent or supernatural entity. This experience tends to be associated with feelings of grace and bliss, feelings of gratitude, as well as feelings of happiness, joy, and pleasure. Comparing these results with White's typology, this type of experience is the closest match with the type named god/goddess experience or enlightenment (White, 2000).

HERE-AND-NOW EXPERIENCE is the fourth most common type of EE. On the cluster basis, we can describe it as an experience of "just being," without the presence of thoughts and their control over an individual. The respective cluster includes the following codes: here, now, just being, not to function - to be, present moment, mindfulness, and timeless. This type of experience matches well with several types of EE/EHEs in White's typology: wholeness experience, unitive experience, altered spatial perception, altered time perception, or missing time experience (White, 2000).

The next cluster, with an average of 12 occurrences per author, includes codes like the Camino takes care of everything, to trust, omit control, and to let go with the flow. We entitled the respective type as the EXPERIENCE OF TRUST. In the pilgrims' reports, this feeling of trust is usually based on events that occur during the pilgrimage. It is usually understood in terms of trust in God, Path, or Life. Looking at White's first typology of EHE

(Braud & Anderson, 1998, p. 61), this cluster fits two types: (1) encountering or receiving something you need just when you need it, and (2) being at the right place at the right time to receive something wonderful or needed.

The next cluster was labeled CATHARTIC EXPERIENCE. It includes codes like a purging of spirit and body, tears, receiving a blessing, or being in church. Cathartic experience is an experience of emotional release and it is often accompanied by tears with no immediate cause. That type of experience is similar to several of White's types of EHE (2000), including transcendental tears, transcendental weeping, and transcendental emotions.

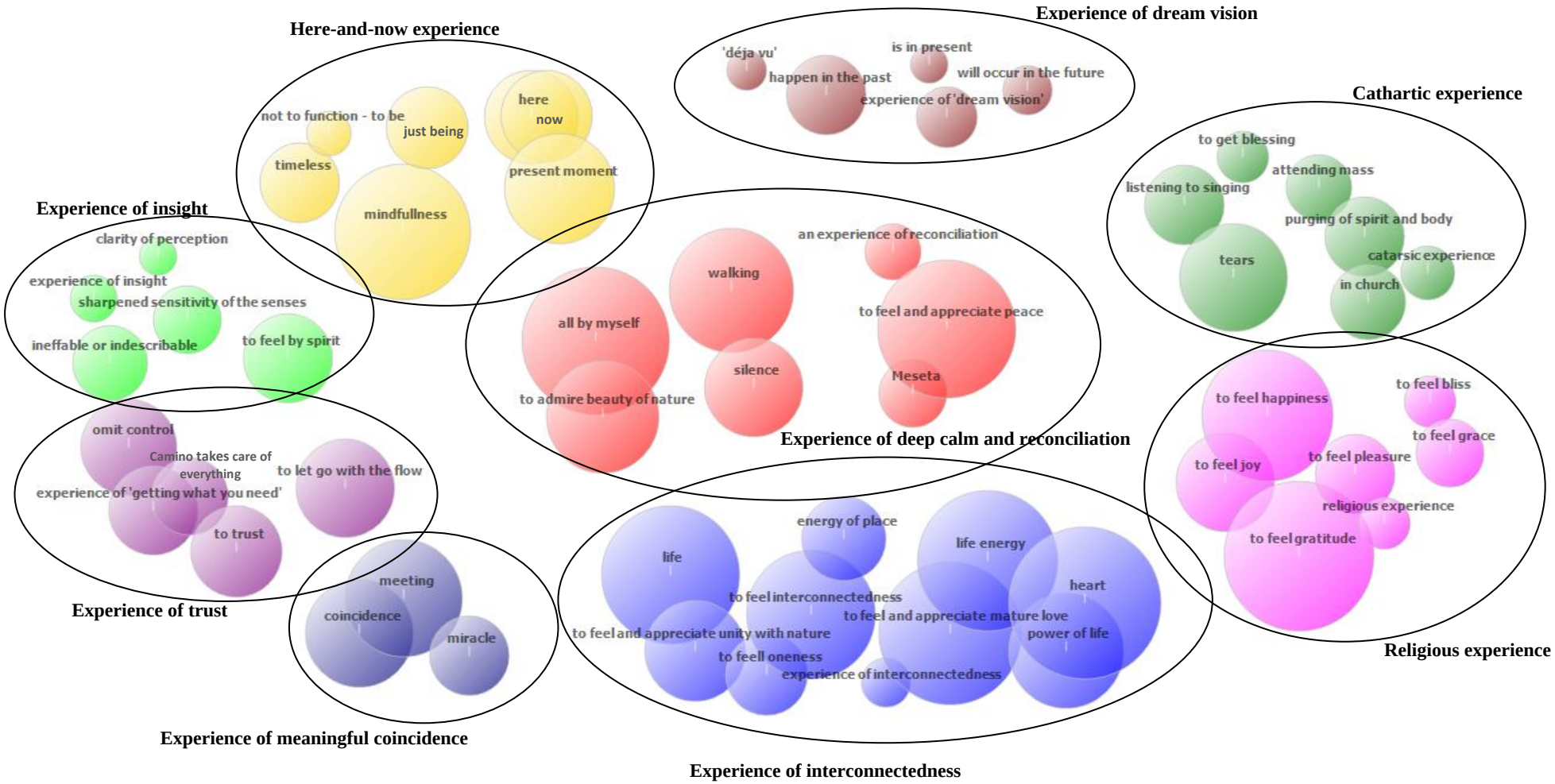
EXPERIENCE OF MEANINGFUL COINCIDENCE is comprised of a cluster of three codes: meeting, coincidence, and miracle. It describes a coincidental encounter of a pilgrim with people or events that mirror his/her inner psychological states and/or life situations. The meaningful coincidence tends to show a way to resolve the problems related to such psychological states and/or life situations. This type fits well with two of White's types (2000): meaningful coincidence and synchronicity.

EXPERIENCE OF INSIGHT has an average of 6 code occurrences per author. We describe it as an instant awareness of the essence of an important issue, which is achieved without conscious thinking. It often also involves sensations such as clarity of perception, sharpened sensitivity of the senses, or feeling by a spiritual sense. This type of EE/EHE is similar to White's (2000) creative "aha" or eureka experience, embodied insights, or Noetic experience.

The last and the rarest type of EE is the EXPERIENCE OF A DREAM VISION. We describe it as the perception of spatially or temporally distant things, people, or events without the intervention of the common human sensory organs.

Figure 1

Nine Code Clusters Indicating Nine Types of EEs



Note: The size of bubbles indicates how frequently a given code occurred in all the analyzed texts. The proximity of the bubbles represents their average proximity/co-occurrence in the analyzed texts.

Table 1

Average Code Occurrence for Types of EEs

EXCEPTIONAL EXPERIENCES	Frequency	Per author	Percentage	**Reference quotations from travelogues (and some additional explanations)**
1. EXPERIENCE OF INTERCONNECT-EDNESS	1307	40.8	28%	"Oh my God, what kind of childish happiness has overwhelmed me. And gratitude. I was jumping on the beach, sank my tired feet into the soothing sea, and let the waves love me. Infinitely connected to the sea and the Earth… Wearing only underwear, I am completely wild and am devotedly enjoying the rambling of the waves and the wind… Is it possible to feel so much sensuality, when you are in touch with mother nature? Is it possible to awaken in yourself the long- forgotten passion and inner strength of mother Gaia?" (Artnik Knibbe, 2017, p. 182).
				"I could almost physically feel the sameness I shared with the other hikers, our universal substance, flesh and blood imbued with the overwhelming energy of life. It's incredible. For most of us, everyday life pushes this awareness so far down that we don't even know it's there" (Brumec, 2016, p. 80).
2. EXPERIENCE OF DEEP CALM AND RECONCILIATION	816	25.5	17%	"There is peace in me. There is no time. There are no people either. Alone and in silence. Headrests on my arms that embrace my knees[…] I'm sinking more and more in myself, getting calmer and calmer. […] I do not cry for a miracle. I'm just calm. And this feeling, which is so beautiful, lasts. I would stay here. Forever" (Sluga, 2017, p. 134).
				"Peace comes on a pilgrimage. Timelessness. You are a part of the Universe but still Unique. Everything is Peace. More alone I am, happier I am, and in Peace. I don't have any wishes or needs" (Udovič, 2012, p. 56).
3. RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE	615	19.2	13%	"Nothing can describe the presence of the Being. He filled the room with his presence. [...] there were no shapes, contours, colors, surfaces, or textures. Only energy. His communication - the association I should say - with my being was complete and whole. [...] This was the highest possible state of satisfaction and peace in which I was sinking. Joy with the admiration of a mild sense of fear [...] I do not remember to ever taste such inner peace and satisfaction in my life. It was probably that deep and true joy" (Potdevin, 2013, pp. 42-43).
				"I felt a slight shiver up and down my spine, and then a presence seemed to surround me. I recognized the 'vibration' of the presence. I even had a name for it. It was an angel, and I

				felt its name was Ariel. I actually felt I was being visited by an angel named Ariel, and it began to talk to me in my head. [...] ‘Do not be afraid of your physical body,’ it said. ‘Learn to have pleasure as you experience it. Your journey is to learn that. Tune in to the experience and drop your orientation of accomplishing a goal. The goal is the path.’ Then the vibration seemed to dissipate, as though the angel had left” (MacLaine, 2000, p. 34).
4. HERE-AND-NOW EXPERIENCE	586	18.3	12%	“I sat there for a long time, just being. It was God’s time now, kairos time,[2] outside of chronological time when extraordinary things happen. This experience of living in God’s love freely given was deeply consoling and satisfying. I had a strong sense of that ‘giftedness,’ grace, or blessing as I had not earned or deserved this in any way. I felt the whole journey on the Camino had been a preparation for this moment, a stripping down of the ego and self - centeredness, and a being open to providence and what the moment brought” (McManus, 2014, ch. 16, para. 26).
5. EXPERIENCE OF TRUST	383	12.0	8%	“Undeniably the Spirit was speaking to me directly. The message was stop trying to go it alone with your own striving and solo efforts; lay back and trust God, trust the Universe and road to deliver to you what you need” (McManus, 2014, ch. 16, para. 28).
6. CATHARTIC EXPERIENCE	373	11.7	8%	“I visited the church and sought for the blessing of the Way. I started crying as soon as I entered the church. I felt humility and gratitude at the thought of tears, which cleanse everything that has not yet been cleansed. As if my soul has been on reset last night and is now slowly getting up together? I can feel that tomorrow I will walk with new strength and fresh energy” (Vranjek, 2015, p. 28). “It's the middle of mass, just when communion rite begins. We enter the almost full church when the large choir, accompanied by the enchanting sound of the organ,sings 'my' song - *Nearer, my God, to Thee*. Wet and freezing, I sit in the pew closest to the exit and my body is overwhelmed with bliss. I cannot stop the tears which drench my cheeks. God, what sign are you sending me? You want to tell me that you give me your blessing. Thank you for your gift” (Kapetanović, 2017, p. 212).
7. EXPERIENCE OF MEANINGFUL	294	9.2	6%	Petra Škarja (2017) experienced meaningful coincidence through meeting a Danish girl named Hannah, who was, like herself, sexually harassed in her childhood. Furthermore, they

[2] McManus in footnote no. 98 explains how he understands kairos: “In Greek, there are two words for time, chronos and kairos. Chronos refers to chronological or regimented ‘clock’ time, while kairos means ‘out of time’ or the ‘opportune time.’ It has a spiritual sense to it: time that is removed from the business of life, where the value of just being dominates” (McManus, 2014, p. 2516).

COINCIDENCE				shared another unusual similarity – gluten and lactose intolerance. Here is part of her testimony: "For a moment, our conversation was already at the borders of bizarre, whereby I attributed bizarrity [sic] to the feeling that we are one person [...] so similar were our habits, thoughts, even experiences on the way. As if my mirror was without corrections and changes. Clean mirror. We have found that our experiences at a specific city, Albergue, the people we met and even the feelings we had of a particular day, were incredibly similar" (pp. 136-137). Pilgrims often perceive that a meaningful coincidence is a miracle, as does Rufin 2015): "After coincidences like this you start believing in miracles" (ch. 12, para 6).
8. EXPERIENCE OF INSIGHT	201	6.3	4%	"It was obvious that because of walking my emotions sharpened, as I became more attentive to the plants and trees along the way. Suddenly, I felt the depth of life, how precious life is. I realized that it is the most valuable thing I have and that I am already enormously rich with that. 'Well, every well-educated child knows this,' you will say, but it is one thing to talk about it and convince others about it, the other to feel it "(Novak, 2004, p. 64). "When you set your brain on minimum power, your senses and emotions are turned up to maximum. Thoughts come and go of their own accord (from where, I wonder?). I used not to be able to understand the statement of the fox in *The Little Prince* that says 'It is only with the heart that one can see rightly; what is essential is invisible to the eye.' I couldn't imagine what it meant to 'look with the heart.' But on the Camino, it simply happened. Here you are always looking with the heart" (Brumec, 2016, p. 138).
9. EXPERIENCE OF A DREAM VISION	146	4.6	3%	"When I closed my eyes, I flew with the guide to the other end of the world, to Japan. I was an old, funny Japanese, very wise and respected. Around me, my disciples sat for a round table in Turkish or Japanese way. I gave them tea, and they watched me respectfully and worshiped me. I experienced the feeling of being honored and appreciated by these people for what you are. I was wondering which life is this. In the past or the future? Then I saw myself in front of an old Japanese house overlooking modern buildings and skyscrapers somewhere in the valley. Maybe it was the future, and this life is still waiting for me" (Jernejčič, 2014, p. 56).
	4721	147.5	100%	

The experience of dream vision involves an inner experience of what is supposed to have happened in the past or will occur in the future.At least three types of White's (2000) EHE match well with this cluster: visionary experience, vision quest experience, and dream body experience.

Typology of TAs

We continue by presenting the typology of TAs, based on the co-occurrence of 38 codes relating to TA. In the books analyzed they occur 2341 times, 73 times per author. Based on code co-occurrence, we defined 8 clusters (see Figure 2). Types of TAs with frequency of occurrence in all books, their code occurrence per author, and percentage in the related typology we present in the implementation matrix. (Table 2).

The most common type of TA, with 30 codes per book, is the one that we call UNITY AND LOVE. It involves codes like feeling and appreciation of unconditional love, unity with nature, following the heart, feeling of happiness, peace, and freedom. These appear to be the main reported aftereffects of the Camino. When they return home, pilgrims tend to put more emphasis on love, unity with nature, and following their hearts.

The second most common type of TA is STRONGER INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS. It appears with an average code occurrence of 13 per author. Clusters include codes like gratefully accepting help, appreciating true friendship, becoming more helpful, and not judging. This is in line with other studies showing that, during the Camino, pilgrims tend to live in brotherhood-like relationships, making them more appreciative of true friendship, interpersonal help, and, as one of the codes within the cluster suggests, making them more broadminded.

The third cluster of TAs is SPIRITUALITY, WISDOM, AND DETACHMENT. After returning to the everyday world, many pilgrims report living more spiritual lives; they

tend to think more about human wisdom and faith and tend to become more humble and less attached to things, people or relationships.

The fourth type of TA is VULNERABILITY. Within this type, a pilgrim typically connects personal growth with recognizing his/her vulnerability. The core idea is that by only admitting and revealing pain one can realize that he/she is not alone in suffering. This recognition fills the pilgrim's life with hope.

The fifth-largest cluster we call APOSTOLIC MISSION. This aftereffect involves the pilgrim’s sense of responsibility to share his or her insights from the Camino with other people and invite them to gain their own pilgrimage experience.

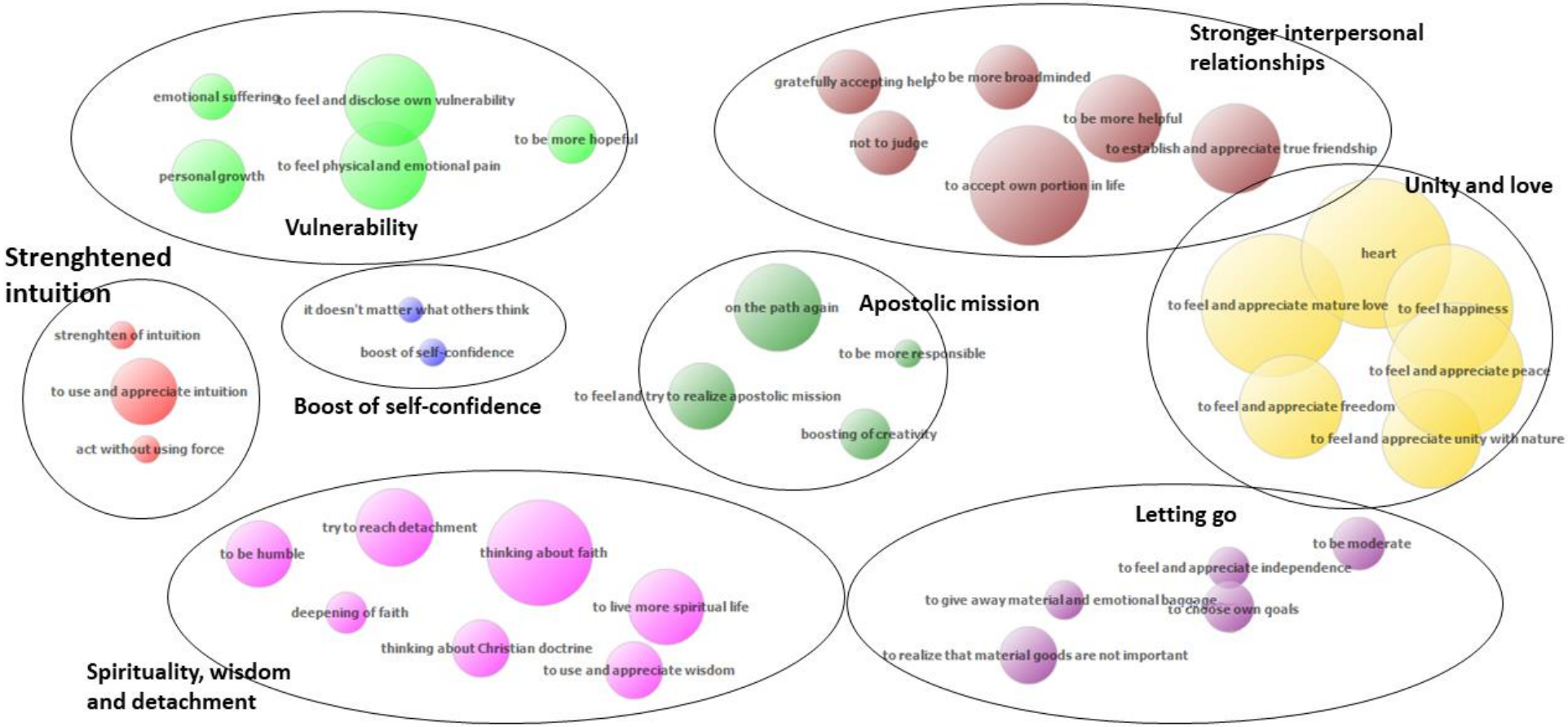
Based on the cluster formed by codes based on the realization that material goods are not important, to give away material and emotional baggage, to be moderate, to choose one’s own goals, to feel and appreciate independence, we call the sixth type of TA LETTING GO. The core idea within this type is that one needs very little for happiness and that, therefore, one should let go of all the redundant material and emotional "baggage" that one carries through life. After returning home, many pilgrims start to eliminate excessive objects, emotions, and relationships from their lives.

STRENGTHENED INTUITION is another type of aftereffect of pilgrimage EHEs. Within this type, intuition becomes a much more important factor in one’s decision-making process.

Our last cluster consists of only two codes (it doesn’t matter what others think and boost of self-confidence) that can both be merged under the title BOOST OF SELF-CONFIDENCE. During the Camino, some pilgrims realize that the opinions of others are not as important as they previously thought. Consequently, their self-confidence rises.

Figure 2

Eight Code Cluster Indicating Eight Types of TAs



Note: The size of bubbles indicates how frequently a given code occurred in all the analyzed texts. The proximity of the bubbles represents their average proximity/co-occurrence in the analyzed texts.

Table 2

Average Code Occurrence for Types of TAs

TRANSFORMATIVE AFTEREFFECTS	Frequency	Per author	Percentage	**Reference quotations from travelogues (and some additional explanations)**
1. UNITY AND LOVE	952	29.8	41%	"Although my daily rhythm has caught me once again in its net, it often helps me when I re-experience the infinite freedom and the magical power of the human body and spirit and their connection with nature and other people" (Djura Jelenko & Jelenko, 2010, p. 140). "Silence is needed to feel peace in our heart. When we are in it, we are united with all nature, with everything that surrounds us. This is love" (Jenko Simunič & Jenko, 2014, p. 67).
2. STRONGER INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS	414	12.9	18%	"The Camino has made one thing very clear to me: I want my life to demonstrate love, sacrifice for others, compassion, and value placed in relationships" (Gray & Skeesuck, 2017, p. 217). "'Take a knee protector,' at that moment, a reversal in the love of neighbor and the perception of the gift happened in me. [...] I realized how much we actually receive when we give to the poor [...] I was surprised by the gift I gave him by having received his help from all my heart. [...] My perception of the exchange of gifts and love changed completely during the meetings on the Path" (Potdevin, 2013, p. 31).
3. SPIRITUALITY, WISDOM, AND DETACHMENT	334	10.4	14%	"Only reaching the limit of my abilities and coping strategies brought about change. It forced me to reach beyond my comfort zone, beyond even the support of friends and counseling. Ironically, it was my belief in the spiritual, recast in the fire of suffering, that was key to providing meaning and support in this darkest of processes" (McManus, 2014, ch.8, para. 18). "I know that all the spiritual wisdom I have won so far cannot help me if I cannot live it in practice. I think that the essence of all life wisdom lies in living them. The theory is always very beautiful and you can quickly conquer it, but making use of it in everyday life, that is art" (Jernejčič, 2014, p. 85).
4. VULNERABILITY	306	9.6	13%	"When we invite others into our world, when we surround ourselves with a community of trusted individuals, we are able to share. [...] And we begin to realize we're not alone in our suffering, and we're not alone in life. Our stories begin to take on a different shape; they're filled with hope. Soon, the beauty of our relationships outweighs the darkness of our pasts" (Gray & Skeesuck, 2017, p. 144).
5. APOSTOLIC MISSION	149	4.7	6%	"Apostles are all of us, because each of us in a way announces our truth to people

				around us. Nowadays we do not call ourselves apostles, but we had different names on the way through history. We are all the same Self, we are all One, we are all connected, so we are all connected with some fragment of ourselves with the vibrations of Jesus and his apostles" (Vranjek, 2015, p. 189). As seen from Figure 2, this cluster also involves the idea of being "on the path again." Rufin (2015) describes it like this: "I would not be able to explain the workings of the Way, nor what it truly represents. I only know that it is alive and that you cannot say anything about it except everything, as I have tried to do in this book. But even then the essential part is missing, and I know it. That is why, sometime soon, I'll set off again. And so will you" (ch. 32, para. 23). The idea of being "on the path again" Remškar (2017) expressed in computer language: "A glitter in the occasional dark eclipse is a wonderful fact that the Reset key is always available: there is a mechanism, space, world, not far from me, where the overloaded system can be restarted. It does not cost much. It does not last much. To restart completely or just refresh the screen. Equipped with a golden guarantee, this option will walk alongside me until the end of my days" (p. 74).
6. LETTING GO	115	3.6	5%	"For several months after my return, I tried to apply my reflections on my fears to the whole of my life. I calmly examined what I carried on my back. I cast off many things, many projects, many constraints. I tried to lighten my load to make it easier to bear the mochila of existence" (Rufin, 2016, ch. 32, para. 18).
7. STRENGTHTENED INTUITION	58	1.8	2%	"It is necessary to listen to intuition because otherwise you quickly get evidence that you should not bang your head against the brick wall if it is not absolutely necessary" (Vranjek, 2015, p. 179). "I am not complicated anymore and I am not losing myself in the games of the thoughts of the restricted mind. With confidence, I follow intuition, and thoughts serve only as a channel for messages of the soul" (Artnik Knibbe, 2017, p. 212).
8. BOOST OF SELF-CONFIDENCE	13	0.4	1%	"On the Camino, I did not deal with similar issues again, and even after returning home, I really did not care much about what people think of me, because the Camino picked me up with self-confidence and showed me where the limits of my world and ability are" (Novak, 2004, p. 88).
	2341	73.2	100%	

Towards a typology of EHEs

In the final step of our analysis, we set out to create a typology of EHEs which combines both typologies presented above. That is, we searched for the most typical combinations of types of EEs on the Camino and types of TAs. For this purpose, we exported the most relevant data to SPSS. These data included frequencies of each of the described types[3] for each of the 32 cases.

We ran a bivariate correlational analysis[4] to build a rudimentary EHE typology based on correlations between types of EEs and types of TAs.

Based on the above correlation matrix we identify nine types of EHE. The first can be called the EXPERIENCE OF INTERCONNECTEDNESS with the main effect of the higher emphasis on UNITY AND LOVE. As can be seen from the table, these two elements are very strongly inter-correlated ($r = 0.944$, $p < 0.01$). Moreover, the two basic elements of this EHE are also by far the most common among the Camineros. Therefore, this type can be understood as the fundamental and most important one.

The experience of interconnectedness strongly correlates with nearly all TAs (the only exception is a boost of self-confidence). It is closely connected to the effects of increased (felt and disclosed) vulnerability, increased spiritual belief, increased interest in wisdom and striving to use it in practice, and detachment in the sense of abandoning attachment to things, people, and relationships.

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[3] These frequencies are presented in Table 1 and Table 2.

[4] We also attempted to create such a typology using Factor analysis as an analytical tool. However the results of this procedure, mostly due to very strong intercorrelations among most included items, did not yield meaningful results in terms of most typical pairs of EEs and TAs.

Table 3

Pearson's Correlations Between Types of EEs and Types of TAs

	Unity and love	Stronger interperson-al relationship	Spirituality, wisdom, and detachment	Vulnera-bilty	Apostolic mission	Letting go	Strengthe-ned intuition	Boost of self-confidence
Experience of interconnectedness	.944**	.701**	*.747***	.839**	.599**	.406*	.610**	
Here-and-now experience	.863**	.657**	.626**	.851**	.639**	.498**	.726**	
Experience of trust	.817**	*.729***	.724**	.786**	*.711***		.748**	
Experience of meaningful coincidence	.646**	.579**	.557**	.517**	.710**	.367*	.895**	
Experience of insight	.483**	.413*	.427*		.492**		.717**	
Experience of deep calm and reconciliation	.781**	.548**	.636**	.549**	.384*	*.690***	.566**	
Religious experience	.764**	.694**	.654**	.416*	.536**	.317	.578**	
Cathartic experience		.455**			.531**		.485**	
Experience of dream vision								.373*

**. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

*. Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).

Note:

- Statistically nonsignificant correlations were omitted

- Strongest coefficients in individual rows and/or columns are underscored; strongest coefficients in individual columns, but not also rows, are italicized

The increased awareness of vulnerability, however, correlates most strongly with a pair within our second type of EHE which can be called HERE-AND-NOW EXPERIENCE with the main effect of increased awareness, acceptance, and disclosure of one's VULNERABILITY ($r = 0.851$, $p < 0.01$). Here-and-now experience is frequent and the inter-

correlation with TA of increased vulnerability is high. Also it has strong correlations with emphasis on unity and love ($r = 0.863$, $p < 0.01$), and the effect of strengthened intuition ($r = 0.726$, $p < 0.01$).

The third type of EHE can be called the EXPERIENCE OF TRUST with the main effect of STRONGER INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS. As can be seen from the table, the experience of trust is strongly inter-correlated with unity and love ($r = 0.817$, $p < 0.01$), stronger interpersonal relationships ($r = 0.729$, $p < 0.01$) and apostolic mission ($r = 0.711$, $p < 0.01$). The experience of trust strongly correlates with the pilgrim's wish to share insights from the Camino with other people.

The experience of meaningful coincidence correlates most strongly with the effect of strengthened intuition ($r = 0.895$, $p < 0.01$). At the same time, it strongly correlates with the experience of insight ($r = 0.789$, $p < 0.01$), which also turns out to strongly correlate with the aftereffect of strengthened intuition ($r = 0.711$, $p < 0.01$). On this basis, we decided that our fourth type of EHE should be called the EXPERIENCE OF MEANINGFUL COINCIDENCE with the main effect of STRENGTHENED INTUITION, and fifth INSIGHT with the main effect of STRENGTHENED INTUITION.

The sixth EHE can be called the EXPERIENCE OF DEEP CALM AND RECONCILIATION with the main effect of LETTING GO. The experience of deep calm and reconciliation is strongly correlated with letting go ($r = 0.690$, $p < 0.01$) and unity and love ($r = 0.781$, $p < 0.01$).

Religious experience correlates most strongly with the effects of emphasis on unity and love ($r = 0.764$, $p < 0.01$) and stronger interpersonal relationships ($r = 0.694$, $p < 0.01$). The respective EHE can be called RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE with the effect of the higher emphasis on UNITY AND LOVE and STRONGER INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS.

Cathartic experience correlates most strongly with the effect of apostolic mission ($r = 0.531$, $p < 0.01$), so this type of EHE we named the CATHARTIC EXPERIENCE with the main effect of APOSTOLIC MISSION.

The only statistically significant correlation of the experience of a dream vision is with the effect of a boost of self-confidence ($r = 0.373$, $p < 0.01$), so we call this last type of experience the EXPERIENCE OF DREAM VISION with effect of BOOST OF SELF-CONFIDENCE. The experience of a dream vision with main effect of boost of self-confidence is the least important EHE among pilgrims on the Camino. The occurrence of both involved subtypes is extremely small and the correlation between the two is relatively weak.

Conclusion and discussion

Our search for an inductively derived typology of EHEis among pilgrims at the Camino led us to nine types. For the sake of clarity, we present them in terms of pairs of one EE and one or two most strongly correlated and/or theoretically relevant TA. Furthermore, we present them ranked by the frequency of the average code occurrence of the underlying EE within each pair[5]:

1. The EXPERIENCE OF INTERCONNECTEDNESS with the main effect of a higher emphasis on UNITY AND LOVE.

2. The HERE-AND-NOW EXPERIENCE with the main effect of increased awareness of one's VULNERABILITY.

3. The EXPERIENCE OF TRUST with the main effect of STRONGER INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS.

[5] The rationale behind this is that an aftereffect cannot occur without experience preceding it.

4. The EXPERIENCE OF MEANINGFUL COINCIDENCE with the main effect of STRENGTHENED INTUITION.

5. The EXPERIENCE OF INSIGHT with the main effect of STRENGTHENED INTUITION.

6. The EXPERIENCE OF DEEP CALM AND RECONCILIATION with the main effect of LETTING GO.

7. RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE with the effect of the higher emphasis on UNITY AND LOVE and STRONGER INTERPERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS.

8. The CATHARTIC EXPERIENCE with the main effect of APOSTOLIC MISSION.

9. The EXPERIENCE OF DREAM VISION with the main effect of BOOST OF SELF-CONFIDENCE.

All nine inductively derived EHEs form logically and theoretically sound concepts. These results suggest that the EHE perspective is a useful approach to studying the pilgrims' experiences and their aftereffects. This is confirmed by the empirical results of this article and can also be discerned from a literature review, since the results of previous studies fit neatly into the framework of EHEs.

We have shown that pilgrims at the Camino report a variety of exceptional experiences, among which religious experiences represent just one of nine basic types. Our results suggest that these experiences are related to the aftereffects of walking the Camino. Importantly, specific experiences are related to specific aftereffects, making it possible to speak of EHEs as specific (most common) combinations of exceptional experiences and related aftereffects. The EHE perspective has proven fit for the study of psychological aspects of pilgrimage in contemporary societies and future research could benefit from applying this framework in studies of pilgrimage or similar phenomena.

Our second major finding is that the entire set of identified EHEs can be seen as an expression of a coherent worldview consistent with what Abraham Maslow called “Being-values" (Maslow, 1971/1993, p. 128) which are at the core of the process of self-actualization of an individual. These values include interconnectedness, unity, wholeness, simplicity, essentiality, just-rightness, spontaneity, effortlessness, benevolence, honesty, autonomy, and individuality. There is a high match between these values and the exceptional experiences and TAs identified in this study. In other words, the experience of the Camino appears to boost self-actualization as understood in terms of humanistic psychology. Given that multiple studies identified self-actualization as an important component (Compton, 2001) or at least predictor (Kaufman, 2018) of psychological well-being, our findings have important implications for contemporary positive psychology. A pilgrimage such as the Camino might serve individuals as an important tool for stimulating their psychological well-being through self-actualization. Our results also confirm that pilgrimage studies should be extended beyond traditional religious studies. Pilgrimage studies appear to be a promising topic for future research within the field of positive psychology.

Basic methodological standards and standards of quality in qualitative research (Tracy, 2010) show that this study is not without its limitations. One of our central assumptions is that pilgrims’ travelogues give the researcher a credible insight into the actual experiences of the Camino de Santiago. We should first emphasize that the travelogues analysed are basically authentic descriptions of the studied phenomena, descriptions which were not limited or distorted by an interviewing process. One potential limitation in this regard is that travelogues are subjective narratives and not a direct insight into objective reality. While it deserves consideration, we believe that this is not a serious limitation given the ontological and epistemological standing of our study, which consists of subtle ontological realism (Hammersley, 1992) and epistemological constructivism (Raskin, 2002).

Consistent with this approach, we take pilgrims' reports about their experiences as a solid basis for making scientific conclusions. Regarding our interpretations of pilgrims' reports, we tried our best not to let our theoretical expectations influence the processes of coding and consequent data analyses.

The second limitation is closely related to the first and lies in the fact that the analysed travelogues were written for a wider public. The authors could have adjusted, concealed, or added certain events, actions, or emotions in order to create a more desirable image of themselves and their experiences. We believe that this might have had an impact on our results and should be taken seriously in terms of transferability to other pilgrims. On the other hand, we don't believe that it had a significant impact on our basic findings (specifically, the typology of EHEs).

Another limitation relates to transferability of our findings, given that we relied solely on pilgrims' travelogues published in the Slovene language. We did not, for example, include citations from the Spanish literature which might offer a broader understanding of the Camino and its effects on pilgrims. However, we see no obvious reason why the experiences of Slovene pilgrims should significantly differ from experiences of pilgrims from other countries.

To conclude, despite all these limitations, the present study brings empirically grounded new knowledge about the concept of exceptional human experiences (EHEs) with its transformative aftereffects (TAs). Each limitation should be taken seriously and studies relying on different methodological approaches and wider samples are needed in order to validate and potentially modify our findings.

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Appendix

Author	Published	Walked	Title
1. Artnik Knibbe, Tjaši	2017	2014	Vulnerable: Stories from The Way (El Camino de Santiago), 8
2. Božič, Saša	2018	2018	Storyteller: 365 inspirations of the citizens of the world and a
3. Brumec, Snežana	2016	2016	The Camino
4. Djura Jelenko, Saša	2010	2009	The Camino: A 800 kilometers long experience
5. Jelenko, Vinko	2010	2009	The Camino: A 800 kilometers long experience
6. Gliha, Franc	2018	2017	The Camino de Santiago “In two parts” 2017-2018
7. Gray, Patrick	2018	2014	I'll Push You: A Journey of 500 Miles, Two Best Friends, and
8. Skeesuck, Justin	2018	2014	I'll Push You: A Journey of 500 Miles, Two Best Friends, and
9. Gričnik, Ivan	2014	2014	My Camino
10. Gričnik, Ivan	2018	2014	From Santiago to Assisi
11. Jenko Simunič, N. & Jenko, B.	2014	2013	Our path
12. Jernejčič, Nataša	2014	2012	My path: The Camino de Santiago
13. Kapetanović, Ivan	2017	2016	Camino de Santiago: The Way of St. James, Lečevica - Santia
14. Klug, Mojca	2018	2015	Camino Francés: My attempt to escape the “nonsense” of moc
15. Kvaternik, Stanislav	2015	2011	My pilgrimage: Along the path of St. James in Santiago de Co
16. Lepej Bašelj, Saša	2009	2006	Camino: My lonely path or cleansing of soul and body
17. MacLaine, Shirley	2007	1994	The Camino: A Journey of the Spirit
18. McManus, Brendan	2018	2011	Redemption Road: Grieving on the Camino
19. Močnik, Uroš	2009	2007	In 14 days to the end of the world: a journey into inner peace,
20. Novak, Nace	2004	2002	The Camino: From Nova Gorica to Compostela
21. Potdevin, Jean-Marc	2013	2008	Reset: The mystical experience of a businessman on the footp
22. Remškar, Eva	2017	2017	And here we go: moms and daughters at the Camino
23. Grešak, Mojca	2017	2017	And here we go: moms and daughters at the Camino
24. Rigler, M. & Rigler, M.	2004	1999	You are blessed, poor man: A pilgrimage along the path of St.
25. Rufin, Jean-Cristophe	2013	no data	The Santiago Pilgrimage: Walking the Immortal Way
26. Sluga, Rado	2017	2011	In the embrace of the trail: El Camino
27. Steblovnik, Mirjana	2010	2008	Buen Camino, Peregrino
28. Steblovnik, Mirjana	2012	2010	All just because of one church at the end of the world: The Ca
29. Škarja, Petra	2017	2016	The Camino: From slavery to freedom
30. Štuhec, Jožef	2011	2008	Across the Pyrenees to the Atlantic: A little different Camino
31. Udovič, Vladimir	2012	2010	I am alive, I walk, and I am happy: a travelogue of a pilgrimag
32. Vranjek, Bojana	2015	2014	The Camino: The mysticism of the invisible world